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WILDFIRE RISK TO EUROPEAN CRUISE OPERATIONS

SECTOR RISK BRIEFING

Itinerary disruption, guest and crew safety, and duty of care across the Mediterranean

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Overview

Wildfire has become a recurring, season-defining risk for cruise operations in the Mediterranean. The summer of 2026 follows two consecutive record fire seasons in 2024 and 2025, and by early August 2026 Greece, Spain, France, Portugal, Italy and Turkey were all managing significant blazes, with mass evacuations, tourism disruption and, in Greece, firefighter fatalities. For cruise lines the exposure is distinctive: a ship can berth safely in a port whose surrounding region is on fire, so the impact falls less on the port call itself than on shore excursions, guest experience, scheduling, and the operator's duty of care to passengers and crew.

Trident assesses the wildfire risk to Mediterranean cruise operations during the June to September season as **ELEVATED** region-wide, rising to **SEVERE** for shore-excursion and land-based programmes in the highest-exposure areas during heatwave conditions. Direct risk to the vessel and to life is generally lower, but the operational, commercial, reputational and duty-of-care consequences are material and recurring, and they now warrant treatment as a standing seasonal risk rather than an occasional disruption.

The 2026 season in context

The 2026 fire season arrived after back-to-back record years and against a backdrop of repeated heatwaves, drought and strong winds across southern Europe. Its scale is illustrated by events in Greece alone: on one day in late July the fire service reported more than 70 separate fires, with the most critical activity around Athens (Attica), on Crete, and on Evia. A major fire west of Athens around Porto Germeno and Psatha burned more than 10,000 hectares over roughly five days and prompted sea evacuations. Five wildfire-related deaths were recorded nationally, including three firefighters and two firefighting helicopter crew.

The disruption is not confined to Greece. Spain and France bore the brunt of large, fast-moving fires near Madrid and Bordeaux, with the Madrid regional president describing one fire as the worst in the region's history; Portugal saw evacuations and highway closures; and in early August the EU placed nineteen Italian cities, including Rome, Venice, Naples and Florence, on the highest heat-and-fire alert level. The European Union expanded its shared firefighting fleet for the 2026 season, and its civil protection mechanism has been activated repeatedly to move crews and aircraft between member states, an indication that national capacity is regularly exceeded at the peak.

The pattern that matters for cruise planning is recurrence and volatility, not any single event. Fires described as "contained" can revert to active blazes within minutes in high winds, and new fronts open with little warning, keeping firefighting resources stretched across multiple regions simultaneously through July and August.

Why cruise exposure is distinctive

Cruise operations experience wildfire differently from land-based tourism, and understanding the difference is central to managing it. In the 2024 Rhodes and Corfu fires, which consumed large areas of both islands, scheduled cruise calls were not cancelled; what changed were the shore-excursion programmes, particularly tours to the affected southern areas of Rhodes. The president of Greece's Union of Cruise Ship Owners confirmed at the time that there had been no cancellation of scheduled calls, but that excursion programmes had been modified and guests kept informed through onboard and website communications.

This is the defining feature of cruise wildfire exposure. The ship is mobile, self-contained and can usually berth or divert; the vulnerability lies in everything that happens ashore and in the surrounding conditions. The four channels of risk below follow from this.

The four channels of wildfire risk

1. Port and shore-excursion disruption

This is the most frequent and commercially significant channel. Fires in a port's hinterland can close roads, trigger evacuation zones and make countryside, archaeological, hiking and rural excursions impossible even where the port and city centre operate normally. Because a large share of cruise revenue and guest satisfaction depends on shore excursions, their cancellation or wholesale modification has direct commercial and reputational consequences. In severe cases, a port may be dropped from the itinerary at short notice, with knock-on effects on subsequent calls. Ancillary local disruption, such as the suspension of inter-island ferry services that excursions rely on, compounds the effect.

2. Guest and crew safety

The direct life-safety risk is generally lower than for land-based tourists, but it is not zero and it takes specific forms. The first is evacuation: in multiple recent Greek fires, coastguard vessels and private boats have carried thousands of tourists from beaches and coastal resorts, and cruise ships and tenders can be drawn into, or complicated by, these operations. The second, and more pervasive, is air quality. Wildfire smoke degrades air quality across wide areas and at sea, and can affect guests and crew with asthma, COPD or other respiratory conditions, driving demand on the ship's medical facilities and, in acute cases, medical disembarkation. Open decks, pools and outdoor dining, central to the cruise product, are the most affected spaces. Heat itself, the driver of the fires, is a parallel health risk for older guests, who form a significant part of the Mediterranean cruise demographic.

3. Itinerary, scheduling and insurance risk

Wildfire disruption cascades through tightly-scheduled itineraries. A dropped or shortened call forces re-planning of subsequent ports, tenders, pilotage and berthing windows, and can trigger contractual and refund obligations to guests. For fly-cruise programmes, the exposure extends beyond the ship: airport delays and outright flight cancellations to fire-affected islands have occurred in recent seasons, stranding embarking or disembarking guests. The insurance position is frequently misunderstood. Wildfire smoke is often treated as a weather-related disruption rather than a covered cancellation trigger; medical costs from smoke or heat typically fall under emergency medical rather than cancellation cover; and, for UK guests, cover generally hinges on official government travel advice rather than the fire itself, with risks that were already being reported at the time of booking treated as "known" and excluded. Operators should not assume that guest travel insurance will absorb wildfire disruption.

4. Duty of care and reputational exposure

Cruise lines owe a duty of care to guests and crew, and wildfire scenarios test it in visible ways: decisions on whether to run excursions into fire-affected areas, how and when to communicate risk, whether to divert, and how to handle guests with health vulnerabilities. These decisions are made under time pressure and in the public eye, and they are increasingly documented and scrutinised on social media and in the travel press. A mishandled excursion into a hazardous area, a guest health incident attributed to smoke exposure, or poor communication during an evacuation carries reputational and potential liability consequences that can outweigh the direct operational cost. Conversely, visible, well-communicated caution protects both guests and brand.

Regional exposure: the most affected cruise destinations

The following summarises the exposure of the principal Mediterranean cruise regions, based on the recent and current fire record. Ratings reflect the seasonal exposure of shore-based and excursion programmes during the June to September peak.

Country	Season rating	Cruise exposure
Greece	SEVERE	The most affected cruise nation. Recurrent fires around Athens/Attica (Piraeus gateway), and on Crete, Rhodes, Corfu, Evia, Paros and others. Repeated sea evacuations; excursion programmes routinely modified; ferry disruption affects island-hopping excursions.



Country	Season rating	Cruise exposure
Spain	SEVERE	Major fast-moving fires near Madrid and inland regions; Balearics and mainland Mediterranean ports (Barcelona, Valencia, Palma) exposed to heat and inland-excursion disruption. Airport delays reported at Madrid and Valencia.
France	ELEVATED	Large fires in the southwest (Gironde/Bordeaux) and recurring risk in the south and Corsica. Riviera ports (Marseille, Nice/Villefranche, Cannes, Ajaccio) exposed to inland-excursion and rail disruption.
Italy	ELEVATED	National forest-fire campaign each summer; highest-alert heat warnings across major cities including Rome (Civitavecchia). Sicily and Sardinia have a history of tourist evacuations and airport closures during fires.
Portugal	ELEVATED	Among Europe's most fire-prone countries; evacuations and highway closures in 2026. Lisbon and Madeira (a growing cruise call) exposed to inland and hillside fire disruption.
Turkey	ELEVATED	Recurrent Aegean and Mediterranean coast fires affecting resort and excursion areas near cruise ports such as Kusadasi, Bodrum and Marmaris.

Northern European, Baltic, Norwegian fjord and British Isles cruise regions carry negligible wildfire exposure and are not assessed here. Operators repositioning between regions should note that the risk is strongly seasonal and geographically concentrated in the Mediterranean summer.

Outlook

Overall European tourism volumes continue to meet or exceed pre-pandemic records, which indicates that travellers are adjusting when and where they go rather than abandoning southern Europe. For cruise operations specifically, the evidence of recent seasons is that wildfire is disruptive rather than existential: calls are modified more often than cancelled, and diversions are manageable within a flexible itinerary. The trajectory, however, is toward more frequent and more intense fire seasons, longer high-risk windows, and repeated strain on national firefighting capacity. Trident assesses that wildfire should now be planned for as a standing feature of the Mediterranean summer season, not treated as an exceptional event, and that operators who build fire-season contingency into itinerary design, excursion planning and guest communication will carry materially lower operational and reputational risk than those who respond reactively.

Practical mitigations for operators

- Monitor official daily wildfire-risk forecasts (national civil protection services) and government travel advice for every port and excursion region, not just the port itself.
- Build fire-season flexibility into itinerary and excursion design, with pre-identified alternative excursions and diversion ports for high-exposure calls.
- Establish clear thresholds and decision-ownership for modifying or cancelling excursions into fire-affected or evacuation areas.
- Prepare air-quality and heat protocols for guests and crew with respiratory vulnerabilities, including guidance on open-deck use during smoke events.
- Communicate proactively and consistently with guests through onboard and digital channels; document decisions for duty-of-care and liability purposes.
- Review the interaction between cruise-line obligations and guest travel-insurance cover, and set guest expectations before departure.

Trident risk ratings — Mediterranean cruise season

Exposure	Rating	Basis
Shore excursions / land programmes, high-exposure areas (heatwave)	SEVERE	Routine modification/cancellation; evacuation zones



Exposure	Rating	Basis
Region-wide cruise operations, Jun–Sep peak	ELEVATED	Recurrent, volatile, geographically widespread
Guest/crew health (air quality, heat, respiratory)	ELEVATED	Smoke and heat exposure; medical demand
Direct life-safety / vessel risk	MODERATE	Ship mobile and self-contained; evacuation precedents exist
Northern Europe / Baltic / fjords	LOW	Negligible wildfire exposure

Ratings use the Trident five-tier scale: LOW (highly unlikely), MODERATE (possible but not likely), ELEVATED (a credible possibility), SEVERE (likely), CRITICAL (highly likely or occurring). This assessment reflects the position as at 13 August 2026 and the recent seasonal record; it will be updated as conditions develop.

How Trident supports cruise operators

Trident provides maritime intelligence and risk advisory services to cruise lines, their insurers and their advisers. In the context of seasonal wildfire and climate risk, this includes pre-season and in-season exposure assessments for itineraries and ports; monitoring and alerting on wildfire, heat and civil-protection developments across cruise regions; excursion and diversion contingency planning; duty-of-care and crisis-communication review; and post-incident assessment to support insurance and liability matters. To discuss seasonal risk planning for a specific itinerary or fleet, contact the Trident intelligence team.

About this assessment. This is a Trident Maritime Intelligence sector risk briefing. It draws on open-source reporting and industry data believed to be reliable as at the date of issue. It is provided for general information and situational awareness, does not constitute legal, insurance or financial advice, and is not a substitute for an itinerary-specific or voyage-specific risk assessment. © 2026 Trident. All rights reserved.